

Bonus Challenge

Justification to Manager

I approved an exception for overnight international replacement shipping because the potential reputational damage outweighed the short-term operational cost. This order was tied to a once-in-a-lifetime event, and our tracking data indicated the issue was likely caused by carrier failure rather than customer error. Given the emotional circumstances, the holiday weekend timing, and the customer's visible distress, strictly enforcing policy would likely have resulted in public escalation, negative social exposure, and the loss of a potentially long-term customer relationship.

I approached this as a customer-retention and brand-protection decision rather than a standard shipping issue. To minimize operational risk, I documented the exception thoroughly, escalated the carrier issue for investigation, and flagged the account internally for post-resolution review. I believe the cost of this exception is significantly lower than the long-term cost of reputational harm and customer distrust.

SOP Improvement Proposal

Proposed SOP Change

Create a "Critical Event Exception Path"

Allow senior support staff to authorize one-time expedited exceptions for:

- Weddings
- Funerals
- Medical emergencies
- Major milestone events

Requirements:

- Carrier fault verification
- Manager notification (not pre-approval)
- Cost ceiling threshold
- Mandatory documentation template

Why This Helps

It removes the emotional burden from frontline employees forced to choose between:

- protecting policy
- protecting the customer relationship

It also standardizes judgment under pressure and reduces inconsistent decision-making.